

SURVIVAL PROTOCOL: Complete Core Rulebook Compendium

1. The Physical Books & Aesthetic

The system relies on a gritty, 90s industrial, and "technical manual" aesthetic. The physical materials are designed to feel like in-universe artifacts.

- **The Player Journal ("The Survivor's Journal"):** A personalized artifact that acts as a rulebook, character sheet, and diary. It uses grid pages, visual loadout slots, and skeuomorphic elements like stamped vitals and checkbox ledgers.
- **The GM Book ("The Outbreak Dossier"):** The master ruleset and campaign tracker. Designed like a FEMA response manual, featuring Threat Boards, Loot Manifests, the Master Map Overlay, and the Decibel Gauge.

2. The Core Engine & Stats

The game runs on a fast, high-tension 2d6 engine.

- **The Roll:** Players roll **2d6 + Stat Bonus** against a Target Number set by the GM.
- **The Critical (Doubles):** Anytime the two dice show the exact same number, it is an automatic Critical Success (double damage in combat, or flawless/instant execution of a skill).

The Six Stats

Stats are tracked visually in the Player Journal.

Stat	Type	Mechanics
Brains	Action	Adds to 2d6. Used for scavenging, repairing, first aid, and awareness.
Strength	Action	Adds to 2d6. Used for melee, breaking doors, and hauling heavy loads.
Reputation	Action	Adds to 2d6. Used for negotiations, intimidation, and recruiting.
Health	Condition	Visual bar. Reaching 0 triggers a Coma.

Stamina	Condition	Visual bar. Used to sprint or push physical limits.
Food	Condition	Visual bar. Used for daily survival and travel.

The Death Spiral (Condition Penalties)

When a player reaches 0 on any Condition Bar, they suffer a cumulative penalty to all 2d6 rolls, recorded in a "Condition Critical" checkbox track.

- **1 Empty Condition:** -1 to all rolls
- **2 Empty Conditions:** -2 to all rolls
- **3 Empty Conditions:** -3 to all rolls

3. Character Creation & Progression

Occupations (Backgrounds)

Players choose a Pre-Collapse Occupation, recorded on an "ID Badge" in their journal. This grants a stat bump, a starting crafting blueprint, and a unique Trade Secret.

- **First Responder:** +1 Brains. Blueprint: Adrenaline Syringe. Trade Secret: Heals allies using only 1 action instead of 2.
- **Grease Monkey:** +1 Strength. Blueprint: Pipe Bomb. Trade Secret: +10% bonus Integrity when repairing a Safehouse or Vehicle.
- **Shift Worker:** +2 Stamina bubbles. Blueprint: Molotov. Trade Secret: +1 Reputation when de-escalating human hostilities.
- **Desk Jockey:** +2 Food bubbles. Blueprint: Water Filter. Trade Secret: May re-roll one die during a Scavenging check.

Experience & Leveling

XP is awarded as a shared pool. Every player involved in a milestone or combat earns the exact same amount of XP.

XP to Next Level = Current Level x 100

- **Leveling Up:** Upon reaching the XP threshold, players shade a Rank Badge in their journal. They gain **+2 points** to permanently add to any Action Stat modifier or Condition Bar bubble.

4. Combat & Survival Mechanics

The Action Economy

Players get **2 Actions** per turn. Everything except talking costs an action (attacking, moving, healing, crafting).

Initiative: The Faction Roll

Combat uses Group Initiative to simulate chaotic firefights and multi-faction battles.

- **Survivors:** 2d6 + Brains (rolled by one player)
- **Hostile Humans:** 2d6 + Threat Level
- **The Horde:** 2d6 (flat roll)

The highest roll determines which faction goes first. If Survivors win, they take all their turns in any order they choose.

Weapons & Damage

Weapons deal flat damage to keep combat fast.

Weapon Class	Base Damage	Base Range	Mod Slots
Light Melee	1	Adjacent	1
Heavy Melee	2	Adjacent	2

Sidearm	2	Close	2
Long Gun	3	Far	3

Death & Infection

- **The Coma (3-Round Clock):** When Health hits 0, the player is incapacitated. If an ally does not successfully apply medical aid within 3 combat rounds, the player dies permanently.
- **The Infection (3-Day Clock):** Tracked via a stamped biohazard symbol in the journal. Infected players check a box at dawn. Meds erase one box. A true cure wipes the track. Reaching Day 3 results in death.

5. Enemies & Mutations

Zombies follow the "Proximity Threat" rule: they always attack the closest loud noise or the closest piece of meat.

Specimen	Health	Base Damage	Tactical Trait
Walker	2	1	Grapple: Multiple Walkers drain 1 player Action before the player can move.
Runner	3	1	Relentless: Sprints across zones and attacks in one turn. Costs Stamina to escape.
Spitter	2	1 (Ranged)	Corrosive Bile: Destroys weapon durability or advances Infection Protocol.

Gronk	8	3	Thick Skull: Immune to Light Melee. Deals heavy structural damage to Safehouses.
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6. Inventory, Scavenging, & Crafting

The Loadout Grid

Inventory is a visual, Tetris-style grid. Items take up specific block sizes.

- **The Rig (Quick Access):** 4 to 6 slots for instant combat use.
- **The Pack (Deep Storage):** 15 to 20 slots. Takes a full action to retrieve items.
- Weapons feature visual checkboxes for tracking ammunition and durability bubbles.

The Tag-to-Table Pipeline

- **Search Action:** Players roll 2d6 + Brains to scavenge a location, earning "Tags" (e.g., [Medical], [Auto], [Hardware]).
- **Loot Manifests:** The GM rolls on 2d6 drop tables in the Outbreak Dossier matching the found tags to determine the exact items scavenged.

Recipe Cards & Crafting

Players find physical Recipe Cards in the world. They transcribe these into their "Workbench Log." Crafting requires specific component tags (e.g., [Power Source] + [Hardware]) and an action during Downtime.

7. Map Exploration & The Safehouse

The Municipal Grid

- **Player Journal:** A large blank alphanumeric grid. Players physically map sectors, mark hazards, and "Claim" sectors to create safe travel corridors.
- **Travel Costs:** Moving between hostile sectors costs Stamina and Food.
- **Scouting:** A 2d6 + Brains roll maps the sector and identifies threats or hidden loot.

Safehouse Integrity

Tracked on a 0% to 100% gauge.

- **The Goal:** A building must reach 75% Integrity to be considered a secure HQ.
- **Structural Decay:** Safehouses passively lose 5% Integrity every in-game week unless maintained.
- **The Siege:** Horde attacks deal direct damage to the Integrity Gauge. Damage is marked in specific blueprint zones (e.g., Main Entrance, Windows).

The Downtime Phase & Complacency

When resting at the Safehouse, the game shifts to project management, tracked on a 24-hour "Watch Dial."

- **Project Actions:** 1 Action per 4 hours of Downtime (used to build mods, repair Integrity, or rest).
- **The Sweet Spot:** 4 to 12 hours allows maximum productivity and healing.
- **Complacency Penalties:** Staying past 12 hours drains the group's Food reserves, triggers Noise/Threat checks from the GM, and risks Cabin Fever.

8. Stealth & The Noise Tracker

The Lead Scout

When entering a Hostile Sector, one player rolls **2d6 + Brains** to move the group quietly. Heavy gear or Condition Penalties inflict a -1 to the roll. Failure adds ticks to the Decibel Gauge.

The Decibel Gauge

The GM tracks noise on a 6-segment dial.

- **0 Ticks:** Silent kills.
- **+1 Tick:** Failed stealth rolls, suppressed gunfire.
- **+2 Ticks:** Forced entry.
- **+3 Ticks:** Unsuppressed sidearms.
- **Instant Fill:** Shotguns, explosives.
- When the dial fills, the GM clears it and immediately triggers a close-combat Horde Ambush. Staying entirely quiet for 10 in-game minutes removes 1 tick.

9. NPCs & The Reputation Economy

The Barter System

Ammunition is the standard currency. When trading, the group's "Face" rolls **2d6 + Reputation** to set the tone.

- **Failure:** Double prices or hostile tax.
- **Success:** Standard value.
- **Critical:** Massive discounts or hidden items revealed.

Recruiting & The Roster

At a 75% Integrity Safehouse, players can roll 2d6 + Reputation to recruit neutral NPCs.

- **Assigned Roles:** NPCs can act as Guards (+1 Armor), Tinkerers (prevents 5% weekly decay), or Foragers (gathers 1 basic tag weekly).
- **The Food Tax:** Every recruited NPC costs 1 Food bubble per Downtime Phase. Failure to feed them leads to mutiny or abandonment.

10. Weather & Environmental Hazards

The Seasonal Shift

- **Winter:** Moving costs double Stamina. Reaching 0 Stamina triggers frostbite (Health drain).
- **Summer:** Heat accelerates exhaustion. Combat and sprinting cost Food/Water bubbles instead of just daily consumption.
- **Monsoons:** -1 to Scavenging checks. Firearms have a 1-in-6 chance to jam.

Wardrobe & Climate Control

Players use [Clothing] tags to equip coats or cooling vests to negate penalties, but these take up inventory slots. During Winter, Safehouses require [Fuel] or [Combustibles] daily, or else resting restores no Health and only half Stamina.

Night Operations

Fighting or scavenging in the dark inflicts a **-2 penalty** to 2d6 rolls, and ranged attacks beyond "Close" are impossible. Light sources (flashlights, flares) remove the penalty but automatically add **+1 Tick to the Decibel Gauge** every turn they remain on.

11. Vehicle Operations

Fuel & Storage

- **The Dashboard:** Vehicles have a 10-bubble Fuel Gauge. Traveling through a sector or engaging in vehicular combat costs 1 bubble. Filling up with a [Fuel] tag restores 3 bubbles.
- **The Trunk:** Provides a massive secondary inventory grid (15-30 slots) that is tied to the vehicle. If the car is abandoned, the loot is abandoned.

Driving & Vehicular Combat

- **The Driver:** Must spend 1 Action every round just to keep control of the vehicle, leaving 1 Action to fire a sidearm or execute a Ram.
- **The Ram:** The driver rolls 2d6 + Brains/Strength. Light vehicles deal 3 damage, Medium deal 4, Heavy deal 6. Hitting targets damages the vehicle's Integrity.
- **Breakdowns:** If a vehicle drops below 50% Integrity, top speed is halved and the driver takes a -1 penalty. At 0%, the vehicle crashes, destroying the car and dealing 2 Health damage to all occupants.

12. The Next Survivor Protocol

Permadeath & Legacy

The Safehouse is the true main character. When a player's character dies, they transition immediately into a new role:

- **Adopting an NPC:** The player selects a recruited NPC from the Safehouse Roster. The newly adopted character starts at **half the Level of the deceased character (rounded up)** and takes an Occupation matching their base duty.
- **The Wanderer:** If the base is empty, the player rolls a brand new survivor starting at **Level 1 with 0 XP**, introduced organically in the next scene.

Gear & Memorials

Gear is only inherited if the group successfully recovers the body. Otherwise, it is lost to the wasteland. Dead characters are recorded in the **Memorial Log** at the back of the Journal. The first rest after recording a death grants the surviving group a temporary +1 to Reputation or Brains out of grim resolve.